THE BEST LESSONS I LEARNT



AJAY BANGA
President, World Bank Group
Batch of 1981

"The most important management lesson I learned at IIM Ahmedabad was to define the real problem before trying to solve it. Getting that right gives everything else direction. But I also learned that a solution is only useful if you can explain it clearly, in simple language. Being surrounded by people who had all excelled before arriving taught me humility. I was no longer a standout, but one among many equally talented and fortunate people. And through the long days and nights, I discovered the value of humour as a remedy for stress."



V. ANANTHA NAGESWARAN
Chief Economic Advisor to the Govt of India, ***Batch of 1985***

"Admission to IIM Ahmedabad was a stamp of recognition that still carries weight. Yet the campus taught me humility first. Everyone there had excelled before arriving, so I discovered my inadequacies and learnt to live with them. The first year was a pressure cooker. With few support systems then, it was a ruthless but practical lesson in handling stress. Business Policy showed how separate disciplines form one logical whole. Turnaround cases taught me that behavioural skills matter as much as analysis. Leadership must be visible, credible and hands-on, and credibility comes from sharing others' hardship. I also learnt to decide without perfect information. I have drawn on these lessons in every leadership role since."



FALGUNI NAYAR
Executive Chairperson, Founder & CEO, Nykaa, ***Batch of 1985***

"The defining lesson I carried from IIM Ahmedabad was prioritising speed over perfection. Waiting for complete clarity only leads to missed opportunities. Managing tight deadlines and competing responsibilities every day at IIM-A taught me that chasing perfection can be paralysing. In leadership, you rarely have the luxury of complete data before a decision must be made. That daily rigour taught me to trust my judgement and act decisively amid ambiguity. When I founded Nykaa at 50, beauty, technology and retail were completely new worlds, each with a steep learning curve. Instead of waiting to feel ready, I trusted my ability to learn through execution."

GURUSPEAK



PROF. BHARAT BHASKER
Director, IIM Ahmedabad

"The biggest shift is from teaching analysis to teaching judgement. As AI makes analysis faster and cheaper, the real skill lies in asking the right questions and challenging the answers. Leadership demands accountability, ethics and responsible decision-making. Our goal is to develop leaders who bridge management and AI, not merely using technology, but leading through it"

India-specific financial databases. In August, IIM-A and corporate lawyer Cyril Shroff co-founded a leadership academy for the General Counsels of the future.

Bhasker rejects the idea that the MBA is dying. India's economy is still being built, its consumer market is about 1.5 billion people, and it needs managers who understand finance, operations and organisations. AI will absorb routine work, he argues, but accountability stays human. "A bank can use AI to score loan applications, but someone still must decide how much risk to take, and own the consequences."

Employers, he notes, want graduates fluent in AI, analytics, cloud and cybersecurity. Managers must learn to frame problems for AI and know when to doubt a model. He flags a less glamorous issue—data centres guzzle power and water, and how they are planned and cooled is as